



The teams will battle it out from September 3 to 9 in Hyderabad — a city that holds special memories for the 55-year-old, as he had coached Hyderabad FC to the Indian Super League (ISL) title in the 2021-22 season.

Marquez recently put out his list of 26 probables for the Intercontinental Cup, and there are some surprise additions. Focusing on choosing “the correct group of players,” he has included three uncapped players in the preparatory camp starting on August 31: forwards Kiyon Nassiri and Edmund Lalrindika, along with midfielder Lalthathanga Khawlhing (Puitea).

Options at the back

Given that this is his first international tournament in India, it is unlikely that Manolo will shift from his preferred 4-2-3-1 formation. In this system, the Spaniard might opt for a more traditional back four or maintain a three-man defence with two wing-backs to aid the attacking

build-up. With a midfield pivot in place, which would act as a bridge between offence and defence, there are likely to be two wingers with a central attacking midfielder operating behind the No. 9.

The Indian head coach has already raised eyebrows by not choosing Vishal Kaith as one of his three goalkeepers. Last season, with nine clean sheets and 61 per cent save percentage, Kaith played an important role in helping Mohun Bagan Super Giant win the ISL Shield with his shot-stopping prowess and quick reflexes. Instead, Manolo has selected East Bengal’s Prabhsukhan Gill as the third keeper, behind the familiar names of Gurpreet Singh Sandhu and Amrinder Singh.

Manolo has the luxury of having players who can play multiple positions in the backline and different systems. For example, if he chooses a three-man defence, he can use the robust presence of Subhasish Bose as a left centre-back or play him as a right-back in the more traditional

Eye on the ball: Anwar Ali (centre), who recently made headlines for his shock move to East Bengal from Mohun Bagan, has retained his place as a centre-back. RITU RAJ KONWAR

back-four setup.

He has a familiar face in Jay Gupta, who he will also coach at the club level in FC Goa, and it is difficult to see anyone else occupying that left-back role, given his ability to join the attack and his excellent trackbacks during transitions. Nikhil Poojary, despite not performing at his best last season, might get another shot, given that Manolo is familiar with his style of play from their Hyderabad FC days.

Anwar Ali and Rahul Bheke should retain their places as the two centre-backs in the heart of the defence. However, Manolo might want to experiment by starting Chinglensana Singh — another crucial player for Hyderabad FC during its title run.